



Restructuring the Socio-Professional Structure of the Media and Communication Profession in the Era of Digital Technology

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Abstract

The media field in the digital age is undergoing profound transformations that affect both the socio-professional structure and the very modes of practising journalism. These changes stem largely from the rise of digital platforms as arenas for producing and circulating media content. Such platforms have redrawn the boundaries of journalistic work and the roles of the actors involved. The traditional system of media institutions has retreated in the face of platform logic, which turns every user into an active participant in the production and construction of meaning. These transformations have touched the tools and the essence of media practice; new metrics such as engagement, reach, viewership and follower counts have emerged. This paper attempts to approach these shifts from a sociological perspective that links digital technological development to changes in the professional structure of journalism. It does so by analysing the concept of competence within the digital media field. The paper also seeks to understand how the digital platform has become a social actor that reorganises professional practice and markets standards of influence. What is taking place is not merely a technical transition but rather a reshaping of the professional identity of journalism in digital space. The paper further aims to provide a sociological understanding of digital media production as a socio-professional practice within the digital economy.

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1. Introduction

The issue of digital technology in the field of media has attracted considerable attention in sociological studies and research. Digital tools are no longer merely instruments of professional journalistic work; they have become social actors that require adaptation to their developments in order to win the profession's stakes. Scientific research indicates that digital technology threatens the traditional system, including journalism, as comparisons have emerged between the quality of service provided by professional journalists and that offered by digital techniques in terms of innovative topics, form, production time and accuracy. Major institutions have sought to benefit from these digital techniques to replace individuals in performing certain journalistic tasks because of the effort and time they save. Thus, digital technology emerges as an element that reorganises the socio-professional structure of journalism within the globalised economy. Inequalities in possessing this technology may drive the abandonment of traditional ways of practising journalism. In this context, the profession of journalism is redefined in the presence of digital products and artificial-intelligence tools, and relations among new actors—digital platforms, bloggers, content creators—and traditional actors—the journalist, editor-in-chief, publisher—are transformed. These

changes are viewed sociologically as a factual necessity that reproduces journalism socially and imposes a need to adapt to it.

2. Based on the foregoing, the problem addressed in this study can be formulated as follows:

3. **What is the impact of digital transformation and digital technology on the profession of journalism? How have these transformations contributed to reshaping the profession's socio-professional structure? How can these digital changes be understood in light of the sociology of professions and professional practices? Are digital technologies complementary tools, or substitutes that lead to the disappearance of traditional journalistic professions?**

2. Objectives of the study

This study seeks to describe and understand the phenomenon from a social perspective, as the media field is reorganised according to a new professional structure directly related to the journalist's social and professional status. It also highlights the repercussions of digital technological transformation on the journalist's professional identity by reformulating the new role of journalism under this transformation. The study attempts to address the relationship

between professional competence—based on knowledge, specialisation and the intellectual and mental abilities that the journalist demonstrates in his or her career—and the emergence of digital media, as well as the extent to which this emergence aligns with traditional professional standards and modern digital criteria.

3. Significance of the study

The value of sociological studies lies in their ability to enrich theoretical and field knowledge. Accordingly, the importance of this study resides in clarifying the relationship between digital technology and the restructuring of the socio-professional configuration of journalism, especially amid the proliferation and wide spread of digital media platforms. The study is also significant in identifying the developments that socio-professional studies have witnessed and their relationship to the digital work environment and to professional competence. Furthermore, it seeks to find an appropriate balance between benefiting from digital technological control in the media field and maintaining internationally recognised professional ethics.

4. Digital technology and the socio-professional structure of the media field

Technology is the science of industry. It encompasses not only the hardware, equipment and techniques that humans use in serving their purposes, meeting their needs and fulfilling their requirements; it is also a social and cultural product that includes the ideas, beliefs, behaviour and all the perceptions and values that individuals derive from their interaction with nature and society. Before being a machine or a device, technology is an idea generated by a specific social need or desire. Its influence thus spans the social, economic and political aspects of society. In other words, technology has three dimensions: (1) a material dimension—machines and information-technology equipment; (2) an intellectual dimension—knowledge, ideas and methods that enable the use of these devices in the field of informatics; and (3) a social dimension—it is a socio-temporal product that does not exist in isolation from its environment (Deliou, 2010, p. 22).

Digital technology is defined as all types of technologies used to operate, transmit and store information in electronic form; it includes computers and means of research. It is also defined as the application of scientific knowledge in the form of applications that assist individuals in their lives and provide them with a cultural well-being that makes them more innovative, moving them from the traditional system to a more modern one that renders them distinctive and creative

by relying on computers and the Internet in general. It depends on converting information into binary symbols and programming it as applications and web pages to facilitate its accessibility for the recipient or user anywhere and at any time (Ghay, 2022, pp. 310–587).

Another definition considers it to be the scientific, technological, engineering and administrative systems used in processing information and its applications and interaction with humans and devices, as well as the social and economic aspects related to that. Digital technology has not enjoyed a unified definition; some have defined it as the mobilisation of all available techniques in the fields of communication, information and technology. It is characterised by several properties: it transcends spatial boundaries, being available without being tied to a specific location; it saves physical effort and time due to ease of use; it can store and transmit huge amounts of information simultaneously; it is flexible and constantly evolving; it provides access to as many members of society as possible at the same time—i.e., universality; it exceeds geographical and cultural boundaries and social barriers; and it permits interaction and the exchange of roles and activities and offers a wide space for freedom (Ben Skahal & Hassani, 2025, pp. 73–89).

From among these definitions, it may be concluded that digital technology represents the global information network

used in all fields in the present era and plays a role in all modern institutions and organisations, especially in the media field, which is characterised by a set of socio-professional features for the group of journalists. The journalist is no longer the sole source of information in the presence of digital technological transformation. Rapid growth has led to the reshaping and re-questioning of the media among traditional media—print journalism, radio and television—and new media that rely on the Internet and digital platforms. This transition has not resulted in technical change alone; it has also led to transformations in the forms of media and communication practices linked to these new media. It has changed the nature of information and the place of the receiver in the media and communication process; more than that, it has altered the role and functional status traditionally ascribed to professional journalists by transforming the skills presumed necessary for professional practice—skills acquired after a specific educational trajectory. The transformation of tasks presupposes a transformation of training paths and programmes (Bouloudani, 2022, pp. 235–247).

Sheramini viewed the audience of media based on their distribution into units or groups united by the concept of membership in social groups; their members are influenced by the norms and judgments of these groups, and the sender

likewise is influenced by this membership and influences it. Denis McQuail clarified that sociologists, in particular, should study media workers for reasons he specified: examining how they understand their roles and how they conceive of the audience; investigating the influence of the media institution and the framework within which they work; and assessing the effect of social background, laws and professional norms. Zelizer divided research trends on the same sociological theses into three phases: the first phase views journalists as a professional group together, with journalism constituting a set of practices carried out by those who possess the authority to impose this experience on others; the second phase emphasises the effects that technical constraints have had on journalists' practices and orientations; and the third phase focuses on the dominant ideology imposed by these practices and orientations, in which media outputs served as evidence of the power that reflected onto society

(Boujmaa & Ben el-Saghira, 2016, pp. 62–86).

In discussing the socio-professional structure of journalists and their social activities, it becomes clear that there are different patterns and generations of journalists who use digital technological tools and techniques due to their social and educational backgrounds and their familiarity with modern technology, revealing the gap between generations in

terms of cultural and social resources. In this direction, sociological studies such as that of the French researcher Rémy Rieffel on the elite of journalists in France have emerged; he aimed through it to examine numerous data and to understand these journalists' profession, functions and advantages within a specific scientific approach. Rieffel noted the role played by the Institute of Political Studies in training this elite of journalists and that 85 % of the institute's graduates represent France's journalistic elite. Regarding how they see their roles, Rieffel arranged a hierarchy of three levels, which he called:

Mediator (Le médiateur): the one who links the source of information and the audience.

Coordinator (Le coordinateur): the one who organises information, deconstructs it and then rebuilds and arranges it.

Populariser (Le vulgarisateur): the one who makes the media discourse available and comprehensible so that it reaches all segments of society (Boujmaa, 2016, pp. 62–82).

With media technological progress, concern is no longer about information and its source as much as it is about the journalist's social and professional status, because information has become available and easily accessible through multiple sources and is no longer the exclusive domain of the journalist. Highly accurate

digital media collect, organise and analyse data and disseminate it to the public. The journalist is no longer alone in the field as before; methods of media work and the social and professional relations of journalism have changed in the digital transformation. Modern scientific studies of the structure of the socio-professional group of journalists no longer focus on the traditional composition—age, gender, region, educational level—but have introduced other research variables, most notably the ability to master technology and social media. The 2018 Media Law defined in Article 79 the professional journalist as anyone who devotes themselves to searching for news, gathering, selecting and processing it or presenting it on behalf of a periodical publication, a news agency, an audiovisual media service or an online medium and who makes this activity their regular profession and primary source of income. Article 76 stipulates that the capacity of professional journalist is proven by virtue of a national professional journalist card issued by a committee that sets the conditions for its formation and organisation, meaning that the journalist has the right to obtain the professional card. In light of the above, digital technology enters the professional domain of journalism without strict conditions, particularly regarding academic qualification and university degree, in addition to professional experience. This has led to the trivialisation of journalism

and its social status, turning journalism into “the profession of those who have no profession”

(Akka & Yousfi, 2017, pp. 402–427).

Dr Hasi Mohammad, an academic researcher in journalism and electronic publishing at Sultan Qaboos University, emphasises that the enormous progress in artificial intelligence represents an extremely important opportunity yet, at the same time, poses a threat to the media. On the one hand, artificial intelligence can help improve the quality of journalistic content and find new ways to report, analyse and market, thereby enhancing the role of the press and making it more effective in society. On the other hand, excessive reliance on intelligent modern technologies can reduce journalists’ roles and shrink press and media freedom. Therefore, use must be disciplined, and professional ethics must be maintained while ensuring legal protection (Al-Rashid, 2022, pp. 65–85). The use of digital technology in media professions thus poses a challenge to journalists both professionally and socially. This development offers flexibility and quality but, in return, requires the establishment of laws that preserve the future of the profession and create an effective balance between human and machine outputs.

The socio-professional structure of occupations is characterised by two main features: (1) the profession occupies its place within organisations that determine

its fields and ideology and the associated various social activities; and (2) contemporary professions rely on skill and knowledge more than on physical strength. Therefore, the transformation in this socio-professional structure is due to the spread of technology, which has changed the characteristics of this professional structure from one based on physical labour to one depending on mental work, thinking, planning and technical supervision (Zayyat, 2001, p. 205).

5. Sociology of the use of digital technology in the media field

In general, usage is understood as the social dimension of a material or symbolic thing and highlights the cultural meanings that arise from daily use. Jacques Perceval was the first to discuss this concept in his book *La logique d'usage* (The Logic of Use), and it was introduced into media and communication research under the term “uses research,” i.e., the sociology of use and diffusion of media and communication technologies (Sissawi, 2003, pp. 19–34). It is a social and cultural phenomenon with symbolic implications related to users rather than just a technological device. Several sociological approaches have addressed the use of technology, including the diffusion approach. The diffusion approach emerged from Everett Rogers’s theory of the diffusion of innovations, which views the adoption of new technology as a process characterised by several stages, starting from the moment

the user is exposed to the innovation until confirming or rejecting its adoption. Rogers sees that an innovation has characteristics: its advantage or utility, its compatibility with the group of affiliation, its complexity and the possibility of testing it. It is clear that the diffusion approach does not focus on what precedes diffusion but focuses on the moment of diffusion itself and on the effects it produces and the obstacles it encounters (El-Deif, 2020, p. 190). In addition to the representations approach, social psychology defines representations, according to Moscovici and Jodelet, as socio-cognitive constructions—cognitive because they result from an individual’s mental activity and sociological because they are the product of social interaction within the group or society. The user builds a relationship with the technical tool through representations; if the social representations are positive, they help with the appropriation of technology, whereas negative representations hinder social appropriation. Among these negative representations are fear of the adverse effects of information, fear of wasting time and the inability to understand due to technological complexities. In light of the concept of representation, it has become an essential tool for understanding the mental image that users of current technology and media develop based on their experience with tools and technological devices and the interaction between these new

representations and actual practice (El-Deif, 2020, p. 209).

6. The appropriation approach

The concept of appropriation represents the process of use. Rieffel refers to the way the user builds a relationship with the communication tool and appears as an actor who shapes and constructs his or her use through their culture and technical and social practice. Accordingly, Peaudy defined two basic conditions for appropriation: technical and cognitive mastery of the technical tool, and possessing the knowledge that enables the individual to integrate creatively with the technical tool in daily life. Jouet believes that the appropriation of media technology requires linking the technical medium and the social medium. From this perspective, individuals build their own logic in the use process, which differs from the logic of the technology, considering that the problem of the sociology of use revolves around two mediations: technical mediation and social mediation. Vedel considers that the use of technological media takes place through the following elements: the logic of technology, social logic, the logic of supply and the logic of use (Qasaisiya & Ben Dibely, 2024, pp. 18–37).

7. Professional competence in the context of digital media technologies

Professional competence is a concept on which sociologists and researchers have not agreed upon a precise definition because it is used in various fields. It can be defined as the ability to perform a specific behaviour associated with a defined goal, expressed through a set of behaviours, movements, actions and words. It consists of a set of knowledge, skills and attitudes directly linked to the particular work and leads to a certain level of proficiency that ensures the achievement of goals effectively (Ibrahim, 2016, pp. 258–271). In journalism, professional competence is the ability to employ knowledge and ideas according to the goals the journalist seeks to reach through digital communication technologies in the digital work environment. This is measured by the ability to analyse, interact and innovate in carrying out the journalistic task. The audience is no longer a passive recipient; rather, there is now reciprocal and immediate interaction, which has led to the reshaping of the journalist's role and of media work methods. The 2018 Reuters Digital News Report showed that the audience has begun to select news from celebrities and influencers on social applications instead of from traditional journalists, while the robotics revolution invades the world and artificial intelligence is poised to replace humans in many jobs, including media. By 2031, forecasts from Georgetown University indicate that the number of journalistic jobs will decline by

more than one-third—about 35 %—which means the loss of more than 20 thousand jobs, while new media workers seek to join the profession. They must face challenges such as the rising cost of specialised higher education, increased demand for professional competence and the ability to master technological techniques and modern media, which require skill and training. A study on jobs and the professions of journalism and the career-path guide in 2023 by Emad Bouchrika, senior data scientist at Research.com, showed that experts expect a positive change from 2020 to 2030 in employment for recorded jobs and professions in journalism—numbering 46,700—and that the most essential skills for working in media include cognitive, technical and social skills related to job roles. Chief among these skills are:

Understanding and communication skills: the ability to collect and analyse information effectively.

Writing skills: collecting information through various media—audio, visual or print.

Active listening, learning and social perception.

Ability to solve problems and handle information.

Technological and cognitive literacy: using statistical-analysis tools and cognitive skills such as English (96 %),

communication and media (93 %), law and governance (68 %) and customer service and personal skills (54 %) (Deliou, 2010, p. 126).

New media technologies modify labour relations; an unstable environment and international competition cause organisations to require greater professional flexibility. Remote work is one form of this flexibility, and this type of journalistic practice has increased the effectiveness of workers outside institutions by raising the rate of interaction, especially given the nature of the work and the non-material products generally assigned to them. Remote work reduces commuting between office spaces and, on the other hand, increases comfort at work, making journalistic work more abstract and more connected to machines and screens (Al-Ansari & Al-Ansari, 2024).

8. Transformations of professional identity in digital journalism

In his book *Cellular on Work Now*, Yves Clot notes that professional identity encompasses the norms, values, rules, and affiliations that define work group members (S

ainsenlieu, Liden, & Titeau, 1988). It also reflects an individual's ability to adapt and belong professionally, evident through practices where tasks intersect with other professions. As Nicola Pelissier observed,

the civic identity of the journalist is a shared identity located at the crossroads of several activities, initially difficult to separate from literary and scientific functions. However, Kheira (2020) highlights that the profession is now shared by a wide category of actors, including correspondents and bloggers, creating an identity crisis with the emergence of a new digital social actor who produces rather than monopolizes information. This shift mirrors the broader societal impact where digital transformation is reshaping professional relationships and structures across various sectors (DOUDOU et al., 2025). Consequently, professional identity has shifted from an identity built within institutions to a dynamic individual identity linked to mastering digital technology. The socio-professional hierarchy now determines the extent of skill and competitiveness, as users often possess multiple virtual identities. Algorithms can bias social affiliations, increasing polarization risks. While theories of social and professional identity provide a framework for understanding these dynamics in the AI era, individuals must be wary of fully committing to a digital identity to avoid psychological loss under technological pressure (Aboud & Al Mandalawi, 2024).

The journalism profession has evolved from an elitist nature involved in framing intellectual conflict to a more popular focus on news events rather than ideas.

Consequently, the cultural specificity of journalism has changed, and digital technologies have restructured the profession. The concept of a profession refers to a function requiring specialized theoretical knowledge and proven competence, governed by organizations that set rules. Professor Farouk Abu Zaid, in his book *Introduction to Journalism*, outlines four elements of the field: it is a craft involving both industry/commerce and individual reporting; it has an artistic relation to content; it consists of regular periodicals; and it reflects the social, economic, and political reality of society. Despite these traditions, journalism faces threats from digital media that establish new forms of communication (Bougazi, 2014).

4. Many studies confirm that individuals are not separate units but belong to social networks influencing their decisions and media outputs. Based on this, there are sociological determinants and environmental influences, including the impact of primary groups. Wis Chaamm considered the media audience as groups united by membership, influenced by norms, a dynamic that similarly affects the sender. According to researcher Lazar, the media industry is witnessing a division of labor, making it difficult to analyze worker groups comprehensively. This requires processing on two levels: the individual level, where journalists cannot be viewed as a homogeneous block due to diverse

backgrounds; and the institutional level, which relates to the flexibility of the institution's structure and the independence of journalists. To navigate this complex landscape, media institutions may benefit from adopting strategic approaches to knowledge management, similar to how organizations operate as learning organizations to enhance their function (Koriga & Kheiri, 2025). Ultimately, as Michale Martine notes, journalists must accept social pressures and group standards while embedded within a system that reflects the rhythm of the social system (Ben al Saghir, 2019).

9. Ethics of the media profession in the context of digital technology

Professional ethics today constitute a challenge in the field of media because technology has become an essential and indispensable factor. With this social technological development, the values and responsibilities assigned to the media have changed. Konstantin and Katerina Mollenbucher pointed out that studying the ethical dimension depends on analysing utilitarian theories, virtue ethics and contractual ethics to explore the ethical dimension of the media and uncover new professional ethics and shifts in responsibility. The human journalist is no longer the main moral agent in the media production process; other agents have entered the process, including algorithms, data collectors and language-generation technologies. The human journalist's role

has thus declined as an ethical and evaluative agent, whereas the importance of the institution and the media system has increased in this field. It is necessary to develop and adopt ethical codes of conduct for algorithmic digital media (Al-Saraira & Tomar, 2018). Accordingly, media ethics are a set of principles and standards that guide the behaviour of journalists and media institutions in providing news and information to the public. They aim to ensure the delivery of honest, reliable and objective media content, enhancing media credibility and preserving public trust. Media ethics are not merely rules to be strictly followed; they are values that help journalists make correct and responsible decisions in complex situations they may encounter in practising their profession. These ethics are embodied in how information is gathered, processed and presented while maintaining transparency, fairness and impartiality. These values represent the basic pillar of media ethics and contribute to building an informed and aware society amid digital challenges and the spread of false information. The journalist's role becomes more important and sensitive to maintaining balance and objectivity in media practice. Media ethics are not just theories but a practice that must be embodied in all aspects of journalistic work (Al-Hafiz, n.d., p. 12).

Some questions still need answers to clarify how to adhere to these ethical duties in the digital electronic environment. Journalists working for traditional media institutions that have websites often adhere more to the directives of these institutions than to their commitments to electronic entities and therefore still base their professional commitments on the traditional media environment rather than the electronic one. Despite changes in the nature of these commitments—including the necessity of defending digital freedom of expression and practising digital journalism without infringing on other sites or hindering their performance, whether by editing materials or publishing viruses or links that may affect their credibility—it is essential to work on formulating ethical charters that suit the electronic nature of journalistic work and cleanse the profession of those who do not respect these rules (Radi & Al-Tamimi, 2016, p. 128).

5. The widespread use of social media has a clear impact on traditional media—on content, role, standards and values, which have undergone significant change and division—as well as on the professional identity of journalism. Traditional media is now threatened because the idea of gathering information centrally by media institutions has dissipated. Media institutions, especially television channels, have begun to compete to employ social-media celebrities at the expense of

specialised professional competencies (Shakarda & Al-Tayeb, 2021, pp. 90–110).

10 .Conclusion

The use of digital technological techniques in the media field raises questions about their effect on the profession of journalism. Despite their importance in improving the quality of media content, expediting production and increasing flexibility, these technologies lack the capacity to generate creative ideas and human interaction that influences the audience; they are therefore not sufficient on their own. Consequently, they should be used cautiously because they can produce biased information and may affect community security and cultural values. This necessitates strict oversight due to the difficulty of determining professional responsibility in the event of error. Since media is a collective matter in one of its dimensions, it is important that its most significant themes be linked to shaping the professional identity of journalists within digital technology while enhancing professional ethical values.

6. Today, media institutions are experiencing intense competition for obtaining information. This situation imposes on journalism the need to integrate and adapt to the changes occurring in the work environment and to handle information wisely, which calls for increasing professional competence and adhering to media ethics while adapting them to modern digital technologies.

Studies and research have proven that there is no inherent contradiction between digital technology and meaningful media content; rather, there can be complementarity between them. This complementarity has become an urgent necessity to save effort and reduce material costs in publishing, distribution and other processes.

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